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Students shout down UT chief - Anti-racism speech met by boos, jeers

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A crowd of University of Texas students shouting "No more lies!" on Friday forced UT President William Cunningham to abandon his first attempt to talk to students since two incidents of racism spurred a week of protests.

Cunningham, reading a prepared speech, intended to update students on the administration's attempts to make the campus culturally diverse and the administration's position on the demonstrations.

The students, led by the Black Student Alliance, gathered on the campus' West Mall, chanting and waiting for Cunningham to arrive. He called the press conference for 11 a.m., but arrived about 11:10 a.m. UT Police Sgt. Ron Stalder estimated the crowd at 400.

As the president walked to the podium, students standing at the bottom of the stairs ascended to the podium, many of them standing shoulder to shoulder with Cunningham.

Chanting students had to be quieted by student leaders before Cunningham could speak.

"Thank you for joining me here today," he said. The crowd booed.

Cunningham continued to read through his six-page speech, although student shouts interrupted him every few minutes.

"The university condemns, unequivocally, racist behavior in all its forms," Cunningham continued, trying to raise his voice above the students. "Those who perpetuate racism are not welcome within this community of learning. . . . The racist slogans and caricatures displayed at Round-Up were a grievous insult to African Americans and have inflicted wounds on all of us within the university community."

As Cunningham spoke, a student standing next to him covered his speech with his hand, saying, "Can't you communicate with us without reading from a speech? We want dialogue, not a speech."

Cunningham moved the student's hand away and continued to read.

He said the university is investigating last weekend's incidents and, once the investigation is complete, "I will determine the appropriate punishment."

He talked about the university's racial harassment policy. Students booed and called the policy ineffective.

Throughout the speech, Cunningham emphasized that the university and students must work together to stamp out racism at UT. But with each word he spoke, students chanted louder - "No more lies!" "UT divest!"

"I think it's a sad day when various elements of the campus community try to shout down speakers," Cunningham said later.

The students said they refused to listen any more because Cunningham was merely repeating what he has said many times in the past.

"Cunningham would not address what the BSA has been bringing up all week," said Suzanne Henry, a UT senior who attended the rally. "He came out and it's like he ignored the people who he was supposedly trying to talk to."

About 15 minutes into the speech, shouts and boos drowned out Cunningham's words completely, and he turned from the podium.

Students continued booing and demanded that he stay and answer their demands and questions. The crowd followed him as he and staff members walked back to the Main Building.

At the south doors, the administrators went inside, flanked by UT police officers, who locked the doors on students shouting "Let us in! Let us in!"

All week, demonstrations have protested what students call racism on the UT campus, especially two incidents last weekend during Round-Up, an annual festival for UT alumni.

The Phi Gamma Delta fraternity, also called the Fijis, handed out T-shirts that featured the face of a "Sambo" or Fiji Man caricature atop the body of professional basketball player Michael Jordan. Another UT fraternity, Delta Tau Delta, smashed a car painted with anti-black messages after a university-sponsored parade.

Students have demanded that the UT administration ban the two fraternities as student organizations and that the university adopt a Project PRIDE proposal, which calls for creating mandatory courses focusing on the history of ethnic groups and a more ethnically diverse faculty.

Leaders of the Black Student Alliance said they expected Cunningham to address these demands directly Friday.

He did not do so during his speech, but during an interview a few hours later, he said certain changes will be in place next fall. For example:

UT will hire a race relations counselor who will report to the vice president of student affairs. If someone on campus has been offended by a racial incident, he or she can take the complaint to the counselor, who will act as a third party to solve any disputes. If the problem can't be resolved at that level, Cunningham said, "it will have to be handled through official procedures."

Seminars on racial awareness and multiculturalism will be created for UT faculty through the UT Center for Teaching Effectiveness. The same type of seminars will be available for all of UT employees. Cunningham said faculty or employee attendance at the seminars would not be mandatory.

The question of multicultural education will be addressed by faculty committees in the individual colleges on campus, not by the president's office.

During the interview, Cunningham also said he is considering eliminating Round-Up weekend because, over the years, the festival has evolved into a not-so "postive activity" for UT.

And, he said he would move forward with the university's pending racial harassment policy, which was created to punish employees and students for individual acts of racism.

Tony Barraeta, a UT law student who Friday ended a three-day fast protesting racism in general and the Jefferson Davis statue on campus in particular, said he thinks Cunningham is at least trying to talk to students about racism on campus.

Facing hundreds of protesters, UT President William Cunningham says the university condemns racism, but his speech was drowned out by shouts. Hostile students surround Reuben McDaniel, professor of business, after Friday's anti-racism demonstration, the latest in a week of rallies. UT President William Cunningham, after his speech against racism was cut short by angry shouts and jeers, retreats to the Main Building, where police locked the doors behind him to keep out protesting students. Larry Kolvoord
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